later in this chapter and Appendix). As we shall see below, the epigraphic programs of these later foundations frequently reveal theological debates, shifts in legal thought, and far-reaching changes in the nexus of religion and politics, all occurring within the expanding realms of the increasingly divergent Shansabani lineages of Firuzkuh and Ghazna – one oriented westward toward Khurasan, the other eastward toward India (see Chapters 5 and 6). Altogether, prior studies of the Gharjistan and Chisht *madrasa*s, the previous and recent analyses of the *minar* of Jam-Firuzkuh, as well as excavations at the site, provide invaluable points of departure for better understanding the impetuses and processes behind the making of these buildings and complexes, especially as they became sacral institutions.[3]

Architectural patronage certainly evidenced the Shansabanis' active presence in an area, perhaps indicated earliest at Da Qadi/Qala'-yi Zarmurgh and the site's *minar*, likely dating to the first two or three decades of the twelfth century (see Chapter 2). But as of the 1170s onward, Shansabani patronage unequivocally demonstrated the mobilization of a different caliber of skilled labor: with Shansabani foundations reflecting the cosmopolitan building trends prevalent in elite circles across the Persianate world, it is evident that their resources were rapidly burgeoning beyond those of a few decades before. Finally, it would appear that, while the Firuzkuh Shansabanis retained a lifestyle of seasonal transhumance, the Bamiyan and Ghazna branches constituting the rest of the confederacy might have been largely shifting toward a sedentism marked by palace dwelling, at least for part of the year (see Chapters 2, 3, and 5).

Shansabani Imperial Architectures

Existing studies on Shansabani-patronized buildings and complexes in Afghanistan have approached them collectively, characterizing them overall as "a remarkable range of civil, religious and commemorative architecture … [that was] part of a coordinated campaign to champion Islam".[4] But we saw in Chapter 3 that, in fact, inescapable differences emerged among the indices of Shansabani presences at early Firuzkuh, Bamiyan, and Tiginabad/Old Qandahar, at least according to the surviving evidence. The early Shansabanis at Firuzkuh appear to have eschewed patronage of palatial architecture, despite its being *de rigueur* for Perso-Islamic kings according to their chroniclers and panegyrists. Instead, they concentrated on more "civic" foundations such as places of prayer, and probably defensive structures. Tiginabad/Old Qandahar was a site likely occupied by the Firuzkuh Shansabanis, a territory morphing into an expansionist political entity; but excavations and surveys there unearthed fewer architectural